

A SMARTBIO BOOKS ORIGINAL STORY

THE BOY WHO SOLD HIS SHADOW

Ambition, Temptation and Consequences



*A person who trades what cannot be replaced
may discover too late what it was worth.*

SmartBio Books

INTRODUCTION

In the quiet village of **Aduro**, where red earth roads wound between farms and tall palm trees swayed above old houses, everyone knew the story of the boy with extraordinary ambition.

His name was **Kweku Mensah**.

Kweku was clever, hardworking and determined to rise above the life he had been born into. He dreamed of wealth, respect and a future far beyond the small farming village.

But there was one problem.

Kweku wanted success **too quickly**.

When an opportunity appeared that promised him everything he had ever wanted, he faced a choice that would change his life forever.

Some people say ambition is the fire that pushes us forward. But even fire can destroy the person who forgets how to control it.

CHAPTER ONE

The Boy with Big Dreams

Every morning before sunrise, Kweku Mensah was already awake.

While the village still slept, he would sit outside his mother's small house and watch the eastern sky slowly change from darkness to gold.

He loved that moment. It reminded him that every day was another opportunity.

Kweku was seventeen and had grown up helping his mother on their small farm. Their life was not easy. When the rains were good, they had enough food and a little money left over. When the rains failed, they struggled.

His mother, Ama, often reminded him:

“Little by little, the bird builds its nest.”

Kweku understood the proverb, but he did not like it.

He wanted more than little by little.

He wanted a large house. He wanted expensive clothes. He wanted people to know his name.

Most of all, he wanted to prove that being born poor did not mean he had to remain poor.

The Boy with Big Dreams



Chapter illustration

One afternoon, Kweku returned from the market carrying an empty basket. His childhood friend, Yaw, was sitting beneath the old mango tree.

“You look troubled,” Yaw said.

Kweku dropped the basket. “I saw something today.”

“What?”

“A businessman from the city bought three trucks of cocoa from one farmer.”

Yaw laughed. “And?”

“And that farmer probably made more money in one afternoon than my family makes in a year.”

Yaw shook his head.

“You can't compare your beginning with someone else's journey.”

Kweku frowned. “That is what people say when they don't want you to dream.”

Yaw became serious.

“Dreaming isn't the problem, Kweku. How you chase the dream matters.”

Kweku said nothing.

That evening, his mother served him a modest meal. As they ate, she noticed his silence.

“What is troubling you?”

“Nothing.”

Ama looked at him carefully.

“A closed mouth may hide many things, but the eyes tell their own story.”

Kweku smiled. “I just want a better life, Mother.”

“And you will work for it.”

“How long?”

Ama paused.

“As long as it takes.”

Kweku looked away. He wasn't sure he had the patience for that.

CHAPTER TWO

The Stranger in the Market

Three weeks later, a stranger arrived in Aduro.

He was a tall, well-dressed man who called himself Mr. Darko.

He rented a room near the market and quickly became the subject of village conversation.

He had money. Everyone could see it.

He paid for things without bargaining. He bought food for strangers. He gave coins to children who carried his bags.

But Kweku noticed something else. Mr. Darko was always watching.

One evening, Kweku was walking home when the stranger called him.

“Young man.”

Kweku turned.

“Yes, sir?”

“You're Kweku Mensah.”

Kweku became cautious.

“Yes.”

“I have heard about you.”

The Stranger in the Market



Chapter illustration

“From whom?”

Mr. Darko smiled.

“People talk.”

He handed Kweku a small golden coin.

“Take this.”

Kweku stared at it.

“Why?”

“Because I believe you are destined for greater things.”

Kweku looked at the coin again.

“Thank you.”

Mr. Darko leaned closer.

“You want success, don't you?”

Kweku's heart beat faster.

“Yes.”

“Real success?”

“Yes.”

“Not ten years from now. Not after endless struggle. Now.”

Kweku hesitated.

“Is that possible?”

The stranger smiled.

“Everything has a price.”

Kweku looked at him.

“What price?”

Mr. Darko said nothing. Instead, he walked away.

That night Kweku couldn't sleep. The golden coin lay beneath his pillow. For the first time, his dream seemed close enough to touch.

CHAPTER THREE

The Offer

A few days later, Mr. Darko took Kweku to an abandoned house beyond the edge of the village. The place was surrounded by tall grass.

“Why did you bring me here?” Kweku asked.

Mr. Darko turned toward him.

“You said you wanted success.”

“Yes.”

“You can have it.”

Kweku waited.

“What do I have to do?”

Mr. Darko pointed toward the ground.

“Look at your shadow.”

Kweku looked down. His shadow stretched across the dusty ground.

“What about it?”

“You have something valuable that you have never considered.”

“My shadow?”

The Offer



Chapter illustration

“Yes.”

Kweku laughed nervously.

“How can a shadow be valuable?”

Mr. Darko's expression remained serious.

“Everything that follows you has a connection to you.”

Kweku stepped backward.

“I don't understand.”

“You don't need to.”

The stranger made an unusual offer. Kweku could have wealth, influence and opportunities beyond anything he had imagined. In return, he would give up his shadow.

Kweku laughed again.

“You're joking.”

“I am not.”

“How can anyone sell a shadow?”

Mr. Darko looked into his eyes.

“Some opportunities sound foolish until someone accepts them.”

Kweku thought about his mother. Their small house. Their struggling farm. The people who looked down on them.

He thought about the city. He imagined himself arriving there in fine clothes, with people greeting him respectfully.

His ambition spoke louder than his caution.

“What happens if I agree?”

“You become successful.”

“And my shadow?”

“You will no longer have one.”

Kweku stared at the ground. It seemed impossible.

But greed has a way of making impossible things look reasonable.

Finally, Kweku whispered: “I agree.”

The wind suddenly swept through the grass. And from that moment, Kweku's life began to change.

CHAPTER FOUR

A Life of Gold

At first, everything seemed perfect.

Kweku's family suddenly had money.

Their old house was repaired. The farm was expanded. His mother received new clothes and better food.

People who had once ignored Kweku now greeted him with respect.

Kweku bought things he had only dreamed of. He travelled to the city. He met important people. He began a business. And the business grew.

Within a year, everyone in Aduro was talking about Kweku Mensah.

“Kweku has made it.”

“He is lucky.”

“He is blessed.”

But Yaw wasn't convinced.

One afternoon, he noticed something strange. They were standing beneath the mango tree when the sun was directly overhead. Yaw looked down.

Kweku had no shadow.

A Life of Gold



Chapter illustration

Yaw's face changed.

"Kweku..."

"What?"

"Where is your shadow?"

Kweku looked down. For a moment, fear crossed his face. Then he smiled.

"It's nothing."

Yaw shook his head.

"You are hiding something."

Kweku became angry.

"Why can't you simply be happy for me?"

"I am happy that you're doing well. I'm worried about how you got there."

Kweku walked away. Behind him, Yaw called:

"All that glitters is not gold."

Kweku heard him. But he didn't turn around.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Price of Success

Years passed. Kweku became wealthier.

But something was changing.

He had everything money could buy, yet he became increasingly restless.

He stopped visiting his mother regularly. He became impatient with people. He dismissed old friends.

Whenever someone reminded him of his past, he became uncomfortable.

Then strange things began happening.

Kweku could no longer recognize himself in photographs. When he stood near a lamp, there was no shadow beneath him.

At first, he found it amusing. Later, it frightened him.

One night, he returned home late. His mother was waiting.

“You have changed,” she said.

Kweku removed his coat. “I am successful.”

“That is not what I said.”

He looked at her.

The Price of Success



Chapter illustration

Ama continued: "Success should make a person's life better, not make the person forget who he is."

Kweku became angry.

"You don't understand what I have achieved."

"I understand."

"No, you don't!"

Ama remained calm.

"Then tell me, my son. What did you give up?"

Kweku froze.

His mother stared at him.

"What did you give up for all this?"

He said nothing.

That night, Kweku couldn't sleep. For the first time, he wondered whether his wealth had actually made him poorer.

CHAPTER SIX

The Fall

The following year, Kweku's business began to fail.

One contract disappeared. Then another.

People who had praised him stopped answering his calls.

The money began disappearing.

Kweku returned to Mr. Darko. He found the old house exactly as he remembered it.

“Give me back my shadow,” Kweku demanded.

Mr. Darko smiled.

“You sold it.”

“I want it back.”

“You knew the agreement.”

“I was young.”

“You were ambitious.”

“I didn't understand the price.”

Mr. Darko shook his head.

“That is the problem with temptation. It shows you the reward before it shows you the bill.”

The Fall



Chapter illustration

Kweku became desperate.

“What must I do?”

“There is only one way.”

“What way?”

“Give back everything you gained.”

Kweku looked shocked.

“Everything?”

“Everything.”

He thought of his house. His business. His possessions. His reputation. Years of work.

It was the hardest choice he had ever faced.

But he finally understood something.

*A person's worth is not measured by what they
possess.*

Kweku returned everything.

Slowly, his wealth disappeared. His expensive house was sold. His business collapsed. His fine clothes were gone. His reputation disappeared.

And then, one morning, Kweku stood outside his mother's house.

He looked down.

For the first time in years—he saw a shadow.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What Was Lost

Kweku expected to feel ashamed. Instead, he felt free.

He apologized to his mother. He visited Yaw. He admitted everything.

"I should have listened to you," Kweku said.

Yaw nodded.

"Yes."

Kweku smiled sadly.

"You could at least pretend to comfort me."

Yaw laughed.

"Would you prefer sweet words or the truth?"

"The truth."

"Then hear it. You made a terrible choice. But a terrible choice does not have to become a terrible life."

Kweku looked at him.

"What do I do now?"

"Start again."

"From nothing?"

What Was Lost



Chapter illustration

Yaw smiled.

“From experience.”

Those words stayed with Kweku.

He returned to farming. At first, it was difficult.

Some villagers mocked him. Others whispered behind his back.
But Kweku kept working.

He learned modern farming methods. He saved money. He studied the market. He planted carefully.

And slowly, his farm began producing more than ever before.

This time, there was no shortcut.

No mysterious stranger. No promise of instant wealth.

Only patience, discipline and honest work.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Shadow

Many years later, Kweku became one of the most respected farmers in the region.

He was not the richest man alive. But he was successful.

More importantly, he was content.

He built a school near his village and supported young people who wanted to learn business and agriculture.

Whenever a young person told him, “I want to become rich quickly,” Kweku would smile.

Then he would tell them his story.

One evening, Kweku stood beneath the same mango tree where he and Yaw had once argued about success.

“You still look at your shadow,” Yaw said.

Kweku smiled.

“I never take it for granted.”

“Why?”

Kweku looked toward the setting sun.

“Because once, I thought it was worthless.”

He paused.

The Shadow



Chapter illustration

“Then I learned that some things become valuable only after you lose them.”

Yaw nodded.

The evening breeze moved through the leaves.

Kweku looked at his shadow one final time.

He had once wanted the world to know his name.

Now he wanted something different.

He wanted his life to mean something.

And perhaps that was the greatest success of all.

LIFE LESSONS

1. Ambition is valuable, but it needs wisdom.

Dreaming big is not wrong. The danger comes when we allow ambition to make us ignore consequences.

2. There are no harmless shortcuts to lasting success.

A shortcut may appear attractive, but it can carry a price that is greater than the reward.

3. Be careful of people who promise instant success.

Not every opportunity is a blessing. Some opportunities are tests disguised as gifts.

4. Never sacrifice your values for material gain.

Money, status and possessions can be replaced. Character is much harder to rebuild.

5. True friends tell you the truth.

Yaw did not simply praise Kweku. He warned him because he genuinely cared.

6. Failure does not have to be the end.

Kweku lost almost everything, but he used his experience to rebuild his life.

7. Patience is part of success.

Good things often take time. As the saying goes, “Rome was not built in a day.”

QUESTIONS ABOUT THE STORY

Comprehension Questions

1. Who was Kweku Mensah?
2. What kind of life did Kweku grow up in?
3. What did Kweku dream of achieving?
4. Who was Mr. Darko?
5. What unusual offer did Mr. Darko make to Kweku?
6. Why did Kweku accept the offer?
7. How did Kweku's life change after the agreement?
8. Why did Yaw become suspicious of Kweku's success?
9. What caused Kweku to regret his decision?
10. What did Kweku have to give up to regain his shadow?

Thinking Questions

11. Do you think Kweku was wrong to want a better life? Explain your answer.
12. What could Kweku have done differently?
13. Why do you think people are sometimes attracted to shortcuts?
14. What does Kweku's shadow symbolize in the story?

15. What would you have advised Kweku when Mr. Darko made his offer?
16. What does the story teach about true success?

PROVERBS & IDIOMS — WITH MEANINGS

“Little by little, the bird builds its nest.”

Meaning: Great achievements are often built gradually through patience and consistent effort.

“All that glitters is not gold.”

Meaning: Something that looks attractive may not actually be valuable or beneficial.

“The bill always comes due.”

Meaning: Choices have consequences, even when those consequences are delayed.

“A closed mouth may hide many things.”

Meaning: People may hide their thoughts and feelings, but their behavior can reveal them.

“Rome was not built in a day.”

Meaning: Important achievements usually require time and patience.

“A shortcut may save time but cost you more.”

Meaning: An easy or quick path can sometimes create greater problems later.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

The Boy Who Sold His Shadow is a story about ambition, temptation and the choices we make while pursuing our dreams.

Kweku's journey reminds us that wanting a better life is not something to be ashamed of. The important question is **how we pursue that better life**.

Success built on patience, honesty, knowledge and hard work may take longer, but it gives us something a shortcut cannot easily provide: **peace of mind**.

Sometimes the greatest thing we can gain is not wealth, but the wisdom to understand what is truly valuable.

— **SmartBio Books**